WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

GHANA

Africa

Information current as of October 2026

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

office@lordwaverley.com
www.lordwaverley.com

WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Accra (Greater Accra)	Capital and commercial centre; host of the AfCFTA Secretariat and hub of an ICT sector that grew 30.9% in Q2 2026	Financial services, ICT, real estate, professional services
Tema	Principal seaport and industrial city, with the Meridian Port Services container terminal positioning Tema as a West African transshipment hub	Port logistics, manufacturing, free zone enterprises
Western Region (Takoradi and offshore Jubilee/TEN fields)	Oil and gas heartland; Jubilee and TEN licences extended to 2040, with Jubilee output recovering to above 85,000 barrels a day by mid-2026	Oil and gas, oilfield services, gas-to-power
Kumasi (Ashanti Region)	Second city and inland trading hub at the centre of the gold and cocoa belt, set to be linked to Accra by a new expressway	Gold mining, cocoa, agro-processing, distribution
Gold belt (Western, Ashanti and Western North regions)	Source of Africa's largest gold output; gold earned $20.9 billion in 2025, about two-thirds of goods exports	Large-scale and formalised small-scale mining, mining services, refining
Central Region (Ewoyaa)	Site of Ghana's first lithium mine, a $185 million project whose lease Parliament ratified in March 2026	Lithium, critical minerals, mining services
Free zones (nationwide, under the Ghana Free Zones Authority)	Export-oriented regime offering a 10-year corporate tax holiday and customs exemptions; attracted $165 million of new investment in 2025	Manufacturing, agro-processing, export logistics

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Ghana Investment Promotion Authority (GIPA), which replaced the GIPC under the GIPA Act, 2026 (Act 1173), provides a one-stop investment shop and an Investor Grievance Mechanism
- GIPA Act, 2026 removes minimum capital requirements for joint ventures and wholly foreign-owned enterprises; foreign-owned trading companies require $500,000 and 75% Ghanaian skilled staff, and certain activities remain reserved for Ghanaians
- Free zone licensing under the Free Zones Act, 1995 (Act 504): 10-year corporate tax holiday and import exemptions for enterprises exporting at least 70% of output
- Upstream petroleum agreements with GNPC and mining leases ratified by Parliament (the Ewoyaa lithium lease carries a 13% state interest) for extractive-sector entry

- Bank of Ghana oversight of the foreign-exchange market; remittances flow through licensed banks, and technology-transfer payments require GIPA registration of the underlying agreement
- Reopened local capital markets, including a GH¢3.8 billion seven-year government bond in April 2026 and COCOBOD's proposed Cocoa Notes Programme
- Concessions for private operators in electricity distribution (ECG and NEDCo), with a transaction adviser appointed and private participation targeted for early 2027

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Ghana in October 2026 is one of Africa's clearest turnaround stories. GDP grew 6.0% in 2025, up from 5.8% in 2024, and 6.2% in the first half of 2026, led by services and an ICT sector expanding by more than 30%. Inflation has fallen from 23.8% in December 2024 to 5.2% in September 2026, the Bank of Ghana's policy rate stands at 14%, and gross reserves reached $12 billion (4.5 months of imports) in September. Public debt has dropped from 61.8% of GDP at end-2024 to around 45%. Ghana completed its $3 billion IMF programme in July 2026, with debt distress risk upgraded to moderate two years earlier than expected, and moved to a non-financing Policy Coordination Instrument. Fitch (B, positive outlook) and Moody's (B3) have upgraded the sovereign in 2026. Provisional GIPC data show foreign direct investment of $2.61 billion in 2025, against $652 million in 2024, and the new GIPA Act, 2026 has removed most minimum capital requirements for foreign investors.

Ghana's main structural task is to put the power sector on a sound commercial footing while broadening an export base in which gold accounts for around 67% of goods exports. Electricity distribution losses of 28–31% and foreign-exchange demand from the energy sector have contributed to a 9.5% cedi depreciation in the first nine months of 2026, after a 40.7% appreciation in 2025. The government is addressing this directly: it cleared $1.47 billion of legacy energy debts in 2025, restored the World Bank guarantee that supports nearly $8 billion of private gas investment, renegotiated power purchase agreements, and is bringing private operators into ECG and NEDCo through concessions from early 2027. Rising Jubilee output and domestic gas supply are cutting fuel import costs, while lithium, cocoa processing and AfCFTA-oriented manufacturing are widening the export base. For investors, these reforms create openings in power distribution, gas infrastructure, energy efficiency and export manufacturing.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Power-sector finances	Distribution losses of 28–31% and legacy payment arrears have weighed on utility finances and foreign-exchange demand	Legacy debts of $1.47 billion were cleared in 2025 and concessions for ECG and NEDCo are planned from early 2027, opening entry points for experienced operators
Export concentration in gold	Gold made up about 67% of goods exports in 2025, so export earnings track the gold price	GoldBod's formalisation of small-scale gold, the Ewoyaa lithium project, recovering oil output and AfCFTA manufacturing are broadening the base
Currency movements	The cedi depreciated 9.5% against the dollar in the first nine months of 2026, following strong appreciation in 2025	Reserves of $12 billion and a trade surplus of $8.85 billion to August 2026 support the currency; apply standard hedging to local-currency exposure
Public debt service	Interest costs absorb around 20% of revenue, and Domestic Debt Exchange bonds fall due in February 2027	Debt has fallen to around 45% of GDP, a GH¢30 billion sinking fund is being built for the 2027 maturities, and the IMF now rates debt distress risk as moderate
Cocoa sector financing transition	COCOBOD is moving away from reliance on international syndicated loans as world prices and farmgate arrangements reset	The Ghana Cocoa Board Act, 2026 links farm prices to world prices, and new domestic Cocoa Notes create openings for financiers and processors
Local participation and registration rules	Foreign trading companies need $500,000 in equity and 75% Ghanaian skilled staff; some activities are reserved and GIPA registration now renews annually	Most other sectors have no minimum capital requirement; structure entry with local counsel and use GIPA's grievance mechanism

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Free zone incentive changes	The reduced 8% tax rate after the 10-year holiday has been repealed and domestic sales now pay the standard 25% rate	The 10-year tax holiday and customs exemptions remain; model post-holiday tax costs at the outset and focus on export-oriented projects

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Ghana's risk profile has improved markedly since its 2022–23 debt restructuring. Successful completion of the IMF programme, a fall in public debt to around 45% of GDP, single-digit inflation, reserves of $12 billion and rating upgrades from Fitch and Moody's in 2026 show a credible and sustained policy reset, now anchored by a non-financing IMF Policy Coordination Instrument. The remaining points for investors are well defined and being actively managed: power-sector finances, a currency that responds to energy-sector and dividend demand for dollars, and refinancing of domestic debt maturing in February 2027, for which a dedicated sinking fund is in place. Ghana is a stable multiparty democracy with no international sanctions affecting mainstream investment. Investors should apply standard currency hedging, conduct counterparty due diligence on state-linked utilities, and can take confidence from the depth of reform and the broad base of current growth.

MARKET ACCESS

Ghana is a member of ECOWAS, a founding member of the WTO and host of the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) Secretariat in Accra, giving investors a base for a continental market. It trades with the EU under an interim Economic Partnership Agreement and with the UK under the UK–Ghana Trade Partnership Agreement, with UK–Ghana trade at about £1.6 billion in the year to Q1 2026. US access under AGOA was extended to 31 December 2026, the US has removed a 15% tariff on a range of Ghanaian agricultural products, and Ghana plans to negotiate a bilateral trade agreement with the US. Exports reached $31.1 billion in 2025, led by gold ($20.9 billion), cocoa ($3.8 billion) and oil ($2.6 billion), and the ports of Tema and Takoradi serve as gateways to the West African coast and the landlocked Sahel.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the President (John Dramani Mahama)	Sets the economic reset agenda, including the Big Push infrastructure programme, and receives quarterly reports on unresolved investor grievances	Primary reference point for Ghana's strategic direction and flagship programmes
Ghana Investment Promotion Authority (GIPA)	Investment promotion and registration body with a one-stop shop and an Investor Grievance Mechanism under the 2026 Act	Standard first point of contact for market entry, registration and investor aftercare
Bank of Ghana (Governor Johnson Asiama)	Monetary authority targeting inflation and managing reserves and the foreign-exchange market	Relevant for currency, remittance and banking-sector matters
Ministry of Finance (Minister Cassiel Ato Forson)	Leads fiscal policy, the IMF Policy Coordination Instrument, debt management and the ECG and NEDCo concession process	Key counterpart for infrastructure, energy-sector and public–private partnership opportunities
Ghana Gold Board (GoldBod)	Regulates and exports small-scale gold, with around $10 billion of exports and a record 100 tonnes in its first year	Relevant for gold trading, refining and responsible-sourcing investment
Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC)	National oil company and partner in the Jubilee and TEN fields, with its stake rising to 29.69% from 2036	Essential partner for upstream oil and gas and gas-to-power engagement
Ghana Cocoa Board (COCOBOD)	Regulates the cocoa sector, sets producer prices and arranges crop financing	Counterpart for cocoa processing, trade finance and the new Cocoa Notes Programme

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The UK–Ghana Chamber of Commerce is an active bilateral channel, running the UK–Ghana Trade Resource Centre and convening the UK–Ghana Trade and Investment Summit 2026 in Accra with the UK Department for Business and Trade. The Association of Ghana Industries and the Ghana National Chamber of Commerce and Industry are the main domestic business bodies, and the Ghana Export Promotion Authority supports export-oriented investors. GIPA runs investor outreach and aftercare, while the AfCFTA Secretariat in Accra makes the capital a natural venue for continental trade events. The IMF, now engaged through the Policy Coordination Instrument, and the World Bank, which backs gas-supply guarantees and education investment, are useful sources of policy insight, and international mining and oil companies with long-standing Ghana operations offer practical intelligence on operating conditions.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Ghana suits investors seeking exposure to a reforming, fast-growing West African economy with a strong rule-of-law tradition and an English-speaking business culture: energy investors and utility operators positioned for the ECG and NEDCo concessions and gas-to-power projects; mining and critical-minerals investors in gold and lithium; manufacturing and agro-processing investors using free zone incentives and AfCFTA access; technology and financial-services investors drawn by rapid ICT growth; and infrastructure investors following the Big Push programme. Investors with local-currency revenues should build standard hedging into project economics.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage GIPA and register under the new Act
Open dialogue with the Ghana Investment Promotion Authority to confirm registration requirements, any reserved activities and available support under the GIPA Act, 2026.

STEP 2: Position early for power-sector concessions
Follow the Ministry of Finance's ECG and NEDCo concession process, with private participation targeted for early 2027, and related gas-to-power opportunities.

STEP 3: Assess free zone and AfCFTA structuring for export projects
Engage the Ghana Free Zones Authority on tax and customs incentives, modelling post-holiday tax costs, and use Ghana as a base for continental trade.

STEP 4: Build currency and refinancing scenarios into planning
Apply standard hedging for cedi exposure and track Bank of Ghana policy and the February 2027 domestic debt maturities.

STEP 5: Use bilateral and multilateral channels
Work through the UK–Ghana Chamber of Commerce, domestic business associations and development finance institutions to identify partners and co-financing.